

# SCIENCE OF READING REVIEW: UNIVERSITY OF ARKANSAS - PINE BLUFF

## TRADITIONAL AND ALTERNATIVE

On-Site Review: November 3-7, 2025

### WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

This report uses evidence from an on-site review to examine how an educator preparation program prepares candidates to teach reading using scientific reading instruction, as Arkansas requires of every approved program. It is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

The on-site reviews are carried out by Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US), an external review organization. TPI-US teams inspect coursework and course materials, observe instruction and clinical practice, review program data, and hold focus groups with candidates, faculty, mentor teachers, and school partners. Division of Elementary and Secondary Education staff participate in the review.

TPI-US rates the program in the three review areas of the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

- Review Area 1, "Quality of Literacy Coursework," is rated from course materials, syllabi, assignments, and observations of instruction.
- Review Area 2, "Quality of Field-Based Experiences," is rated from placement records, observation and feedback evidence, and focus groups with candidates, mentor teachers, faculty, and school partners.
- Review Area 3, "Quality of Performance Management and Continuous Improvement," is rated from program data systems, quality-control checkpoints, monitoring practice, and partnership evidence.

Every review area receives a rating. Depending on the framework version, the report may also rate each criterion; some earlier reports discuss every criterion without stating a separate rating for it. Performance Levels are defined as follows, in language drawn from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework:

| PERFORMANCE LEVEL      | WHAT THE RATING MEANS                                                                                    |
|------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>4 — EXCEEDS</b>     | Coursework and training <b>CONSISTENTLY</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.     |
| <b>3 — MEETS</b>       | Coursework and training <b>USUALLY</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.          |
| <b>2 — APPROACHING</b> | Coursework and training <b>INCONSISTENTLY</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction.   |
| <b>1 — BELOW</b>       | Coursework and training <b>RARELY OR DO NOT</b> address the characteristics of high-quality instruction. |

# UNIVERSITY OF ARKANSAS - PINE BLUFF

## TRADITIONAL AND ALTERNATIVE

| REVIEW AREA PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                       |                                          |                                         |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| REVIEW AREA 1<br>LITERACY COURSEWORK                                                                                                                 | REVIEW AREA 2<br>FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES | REVIEW AREA 3<br>PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT |
| <b>APPROACHING</b>                                                                                                                                   | <b>APPROACHING</b>                       | <b>APPROACHING</b>                      |
| CRITERIA REVIEWED                                                                                                                                    |                                          |                                         |
| 9                                                                                                                                                    | 11                                       | 7                                       |
| CORRECTIVE ACTION STATUS                                                                                                                             |                                          |                                         |
| Corrective action plan in place for this review cycle. This program is carrying out a corrective action plan with the Division covering ten actions. |                                          |                                         |

## PROGRAM INFORMATION

|                  |                                             |
|------------------|---------------------------------------------|
| INSTITUTION NAME | University of Arkansas - Pine Bluff         |
| LOCATION         | Pine Bluff, Arkansas                        |
| PROGRAM REVIEWED | Educator preparation program, literacy      |
| PATHWAY          | Traditional and Alternative                 |
| REVIEW FRAMEWORK | TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024) |
| REVIEWING BODY   | Teacher Prep Inspection-US (TPI-US)         |
| SITE VISIT DATES | November 3-7, 2025                          |

# REVIEW AREA 1: QUALITY OF LITERACY COURSEWORK

| REVIEW AREA 1 PERFORMANCE LEVEL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>APPROACHING</b>   9 criteria reviewed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                    |
| CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |                    |
| Overview of the science of reading                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Concepts of print instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Collaborative communication, oral language instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Phonological and phonemic awareness instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Phonics, orthography, automatic word recognition instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Fluency instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Vocabulary instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Text comprehension instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Writing instruction                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | <b>Below</b>       |
| WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |                    |
| <p>Reviewers found that RDNG 4315 Methods of Teaching Reading and ELED 3324 built a connected science of reading knowledge base through explicit routines, quizzes and exams, and field tasks reinforced by high-quality instructional materials. Phonological and phonemic awareness, phonics and orthography, fluency, and vocabulary were the strongest components, supported by decoding surveys, spelling analyses, rapid recognition chart work, and Frayer models. Writing instruction was rated below expectations because reviewers found it largely missing as a coherent strand, appearing in course outcomes rather than as a scored, cumulative sequence. Concepts of print appeared intermittently, oral language structures were rarely named, and comprehension questioning seldom required students to return to the text for evidence.</p> |                    |
| REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Build candidates' understanding of reading and writing reciprocity and embed integrated practice across the literacy course sequence</li> <li>• Strengthen coursework and field applications focused on differentiation for neurodiverse, linguistically diverse, and gifted learners</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                    |
| CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                    |
| Six of the ten corrective actions target this review area.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                    |

## REVIEW AREA 2: QUALITY OF FIELD-BASED EXPERIENCES

| REVIEW AREA 2 PERFORMANCE LEVEL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                    |
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| <b>APPROACHING</b>   11 criteria reviewed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |                    |
| CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                    |
| Selection of clinical placement schools                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                           | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Selection of cooperating teachers (mentor teachers)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                               | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Opportunities to observe models of effective early literacy practice                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Field-based placements provide opportunities to use HQIM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Responsibilities build to candidate readiness for full responsibility                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Opportunities to apply learning about multilingual children                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Opportunities to apply learning about students who experience difficulty reading                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Mentor teachers are skillful and can coach candidates                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Faculty and supervisors guide and evaluate candidates through training                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Quality of written and oral feedback                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Student engagement and candidate impact on student learning                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | <b>Approaching</b> |
| WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                    |
| <p>Reviewers found that the program selected cooperating teachers rigorously, requiring state ratings of effective or highly effective plus Teach PRIDE Academy participation and NIET and RISE mentor training, and that candidates observed PK-3 literacy instruction live and on video and used high-quality instructional materials. Placements in Pine Bluff, Dumas, and Forrest City served high-need students but were not consistently high performing. Reviewers also found uneven preparation with multilingual learners and students with dyslexia, mentor and supervisor training that was not required or tracked, and observation feedback that was largely descriptive, seldom cited student evidence, and rarely named measurable next steps.</p> |                    |
| REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>Formalize and document training expectations and participation in professional development focused on science of reading content, HQIM analysis, and practice-based pedagogy</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |                    |
| CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                    |
| Four of the ten corrective actions target this review area.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                    |

## REVIEW AREA 3: QUALITY OF PERFORMANCE MANAGEMENT AND CONTINUOUS IMPROVEMENT

| REVIEW AREA 3 PERFORMANCE LEVEL                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |                    |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------|
| <b>APPROACHING</b>   7 criteria reviewed                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                    |
| CRITERION PERFORMANCE LEVELS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |                    |
| Quality of data the program collects and uses                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Internal quality control gates (or checkpoints) and intervention plans                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            | <b>Meets</b>       |
| Quality of monitoring                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Monitoring coursework quality, teaching quality, and clinical connections                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Quality improvement planning                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Partnerships improve candidate experiences with HQIM                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | <b>Approaching</b> |
| Evaluation of partnerships for readiness to teach early literacy                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | <b>Approaching</b> |
| WHAT THE REVIEWERS FOUND                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                          |                    |
| <p>Reviewers found that the program collected course grades, observation scores, Praxis results, dispositional and attendance data, and checkpoint outcomes, and reviewed them through its quality assurance handbook, an admissions, retention, and exit committee, and an annual assessment day. Internal gates at admission, pre-residency, intent to student teach, clinical residency, and completion met expectations, with two phases of remediation plans carrying written goals, supports, and timelines. Reviewers found no systematic rater reliability or feedback audits, mentor information housed separately from candidate data, and fragmented monitoring across cohorts. Improvement plans lacked measurable targets, timelines, responsible parties, and follow-up checks.</p> |                    |
| REVIEW RECOMMENDATIONS                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                    |
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> <li>• Develop a program-wide monitoring system tracking key program processes and the strength of connections between coursework and clinical practice</li> </ul>                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |                    |
| CORRECTIVE ACTIONS TARGETING THIS AREA                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |                    |
| One of the ten corrective actions targets this review area.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |                    |

# CORRECTIVE ACTION PLAN

Where a review identifies findings that require follow-up, the program develops a corrective action plan with the Division of Elementary and Secondary Education. The recommendations under each review area above are the reviewers' advice; the plan below is the program's formal response, monitored by the Division. Actions are grouped by the review area whose findings prompted them.

| TOTAL ACTIONS | HIGH PRIORITY | MEDIUM PRIORITY | LOW PRIORITY |
|---------------|---------------|-----------------|--------------|
| <b>10</b>     | <b>7</b>      | <b>3</b>        | <b>0</b>     |

The plan sets out 10 corrective actions: 7 high priority and 3 medium priority. The priorities are the plan's own. Some actions target more than one review area, so the per-area counts shown under each review area add to more than the total.

## ACTIONS THE PROGRAM IS TAKING

| PRIORITY                | ACTION                                                                                                | FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT                                        | SUCCESS METRICS                                                                                                                                                                           |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA1      | Establish a PK-3 Writing Strand across the literacy sequence                                          | RA1: Writing Instruction (Below)                                | ≥90% of candidates meet proficiency on a writing signature assessment; field observations include writing instruction evidence; candidates can score student writing with a common rubric |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA1      | Integrate Reading↔Writing reciprocity in pre-residency tasks                                          | RA1: Reading-Writing integration recommendation                 | Candidates demonstrate transfer links in scored tasks; lesson plans explicitly connect decoding/encoding and comprehension/writing                                                        |
| <b>MEDIUM</b><br>RA1    | Strengthen Concepts of Print instruction with modeled routines + field rehearsal                      | RA1: Concepts of Print (Approaching)                            | Candidates score proficient on a print concepts mini-assessment; field evidence shows correct implementation of print routines                                                            |
| <b>MEDIUM</b><br>RA1    | Make Oral Language explicit (structures + routines), especially for multilingual learners             | RA1: Oral Language (Approaching); Diverse Learners              | Candidate plans include oral language objectives and supports; observations show structured discussion routines                                                                           |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA1      | Tighten HQIM-aligned comprehension instruction (text-dependent questioning progression)               | RA1: Text Comprehension (Approaching)                           | Candidate work demonstrates text-dependent sequences; supervisors rate comprehension lessons proficient using common rubric                                                               |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA1, RA2 | Systematize differentiation for neurodiverse, multilingual, gifted learners across coursework + field | RA1 recommendation on learner variability; RA2 application gaps | ≥80% of candidates demonstrate data-based differentiation in observed lessons; fewer content errors noted in observations                                                                 |

| PRIORITY             | ACTION                                                                                                           | FINDING THAT REQUIRED IT                                                            | SUCCESS METRICS                                                                                                            |
|----------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>MEDIUM</b><br>RA2 | Improve selection of clinical placement schools toward high-performing/improving + HQIM + strong SoR mentors     | RA2: Selection of clinical placement schools (Approaching)                          | Increasing % of placements meeting criteria year-over-year; candidates report stronger instructional modeling              |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA2   | Formalize and document SoR/HQIM coaching training for faculty, supervisors, and cooperating teachers             | RA2 recommendation: stakeholder training and participation documentation            | 100% supervisors/mentors complete required modules; calibration scores improve across evaluators                           |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA2   | Standardize feedback quality (student-evidence based, goal-linked, next steps) + audit feedback                  | RA2: Quality of written/oral feedback (Approaching)                                 | ≥90% feedback samples meet quality rubric; candidates can name next steps and implement them                               |
| <b>HIGH</b><br>RA3   | Build RA3 integrated monitoring: dashboard + reliability checks + term-by-term coursework-clinical feedback loop | RA3: Quality of data (Approaching); monitoring + improvement planning (Approaching) | Dashboard used on a set schedule; documented course changes tied to field patterns; improved consistency across evaluators |

## OVERSIGHT

Each action in the plan carries an evidence requirement and a framework criterion it answers to. The plan presents its success metrics as suggested measures rather than settled targets, and the program supplies the responsible owner and the completion timeline for each action when it returns the plan to the Division. Those owner and timeline entries are not recorded in the plan as issued and are therefore not published here.

*Sources: TPI-US Written Report & Recommendations, University of Arkansas - Pine Bluff, November 3-7, 2025, conducted under the TPI-US Arkansas SOR Review Framework (2024). University of Arkansas - Pine Bluff Arkansas Science of Reading (SoR) Corrective Action Plan, Arkansas DESE. Rating scale language quoted from the Arkansas Literacy Review Framework.*